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ROCKET MAN

On May 14, 1962, Nikita Khrushchev left Moscow for a long-planned visit to Bulgaria, one of the most reliable Soviet satellites in Eastern Europe. It was linked to Russia by culture, religion, and common struggle against the Ottoman Turks during the tsarist era. In fact, both countries had previously been ruled by tsars; now they were headed by first secretaries. Khrushchev was going to Bulgaria to sign a cooperation agreement and celebrate Soviet-Bulgarian friendship with his client and counterpart, Todor Zhivkov.

Zhivkov, who became first secretary of the Bulgarian Communist Party in 1954, after Stalin's death, and held that office until the fall of the communist regime in 1989, mobilized hundreds of thousands of citizens and shepherded them to rallies organized in Khrushchev's honor. A quarter of a million people gathered in the main square and adjoining streets of Sofia on May 19 to greet the visitor from Moscow. For a country with a population below eight million whose capital had fewer than eight hundred